BOOKS

FOUND IN TRANSLATION

Meena Arora Nayak's retelling of Vishnusharma's *Panchatantra* seals her reputation as an inspired interpreter of classical Sanskrit tales

The *Panchatantra* is one of those story collections that is everywhere and all the time, not simply in the subcontinent, where it is believed to have originated, but in animal stories across Europe and West Asia. As the stories settle into different languages, cultures and regions, their flora and fauna change, as does the religious and metaphysical universe they inhabit, but the message they carry—how to make friends, how to deal with the loss of power and pelf, how to guard yourself against reckless behaviour—remains the same. It's a manual for how to live in the world of *realpolitik*, how to be prepared as a king or a ruler to maintain power, how to nurture allies and eliminate enemies and how to handle reversals and misfortunes.

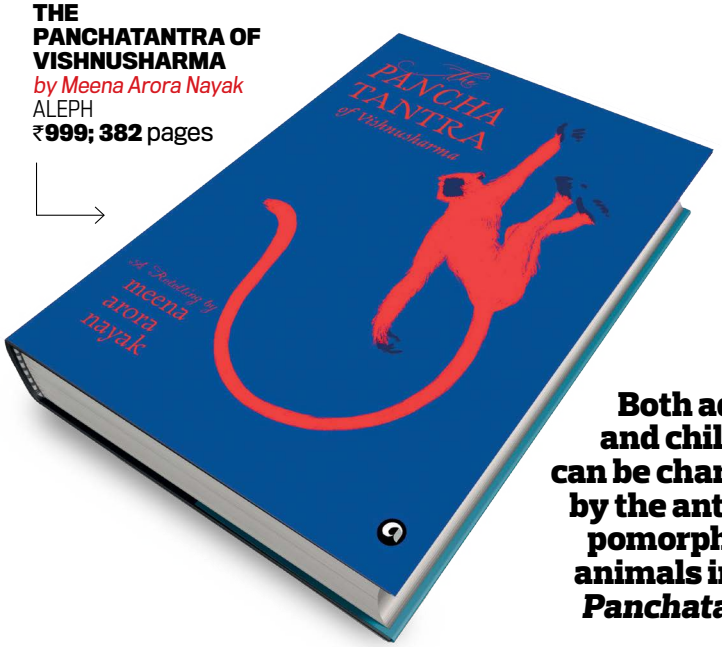
The many versions and renditions of the Indian story have a frame, of course, that explains the genesis and purpose of the text. A king has three sons who are not worth much, they are lazy and spoilt and, actually, rather dull-witted. Worried for the future of his kingdom, the king seeks a way to teach them about statecraft and good governance and how to protect their legacy. And so the wise sage Vishnusharma is appointed to tutor the brats and transform them into reasonable heirs to the throne.

Many of the stories that appear in this well-loved and well-known text are older and come to us from the Buddhist Jatakas, where they depict the selfless actions of the Buddha in his previous lives. But by 300 CE, when Vishnusharma's version was compiled with its frame story of incompetent princes who need to be schooled into kingship, the book is clearly a manual for ruling elites and upper castes/ classes. Scholars have commented on the *Panchatantra's* closeness to the *Arthashastra* and have pointed out that the text was put together at the same time as other dharma and niti shastras. Thus, it reflects the same concerns and proclivities as its companion texts—concerns that we now find problematic in terms of caste, gender and other hierarchical exclusions. Nonetheless, both children and adults can be charmed by the anthropomorphised animals in the *Panchatantra* who play out human strengths and weaknesses, our vanities and our foibles. But as we find our pleasures in the *Panchatantra*, it would be good to remember whence it came—not so that we can reject it altogether, but so that we can see it better for what it is.

Aleph has found a gem in Meena Arora Nayak as an interpreter of classical Sanskrit tales. She already has behind her lucid and extremely enjoyable renditions of stories from the *Kathasaritsagara* and a charming collection, *Adbhut*, about "marvellous creatures" from Indian folklore. Her new retelling of the *Panchatantra* has all the virtues of her previous volumes and is supported (as are the others) by a solid, informative and accessible 'Introduction' to the original work and to her process, including the texts and translations she has consulted. This book will bring joy to the general reader and warm companionship to the scholar looking for something a little more than what the text and earlier translations provide. Brava! ■

Arshia Sattar

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by Meena Arora Nayak
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